If you rely on someone like I do on Tony, the honesty and openness you have between you means it has to be more than just a business arrangement. He's my agent. He's also one of my very closest friends, a person I know I can turn to for advice or guidance. We can talk things through, not only about my career but about almost every other aspect of my life as well. In many ways, Tony knows me better than anyone. The only problem we had at United, though, was a tricky one. He and the manager didn't get on; or, at least, the manager didn't get on with him. I should have known: when I first told the boss that I'd signed up to be represented by Tony, which happened a few months after we'd met, I got ripped into on the spot.

'What do you need an agent for? Haven't you always been looked after at the club?'

Tony made a point of telling the boss, too, and even went round to his house to do it face to face. There are stories that the manager ended up chasing Tony down the street. That never happened but I do know Tony got an even worse grilling about it than I did.

I always regretted that the United manager wouldn't talk to my agent.

It might have made all our lives easier over the years. And I think, if they had sat down together, the boss might have realized he'd misjudged Tony. Yes, he's an agent but he also loves soccer and always understood that for me United was the foundation stone for everything else that went on in my professional life. Tony would never say or do anything to compromise my priorities. I think back to times when the boss was worried or angry about me; I remember situations where we fell out. Those bust-ups always seemed to get blown up out of all proportion. They happen at every soccer club all the time without having to make headlines. I think we could have kept a lid on things and settled differences sooner if the boss and Tony could have had the kind of relationship in which they could pickup the phone and speak to each other.

The frost between Tony and the boss wasn't what held up negotiations over my new deal at Old Trafford, though. It was a pretty complicated bit of paperwork, especially because my image rights had to be built in somewhere so that United could use my face and name as an individual in their commercial operations. I think it took something like two dozen meetings before everything was squared away. I'm happy I only had to show my face at one of them. It might have needed a year and a half to come up with the right contract but, as far as I was concerned, the talking was all about details. In the meantime, it was interesting—flattering, even—hearing that other clubs, big